

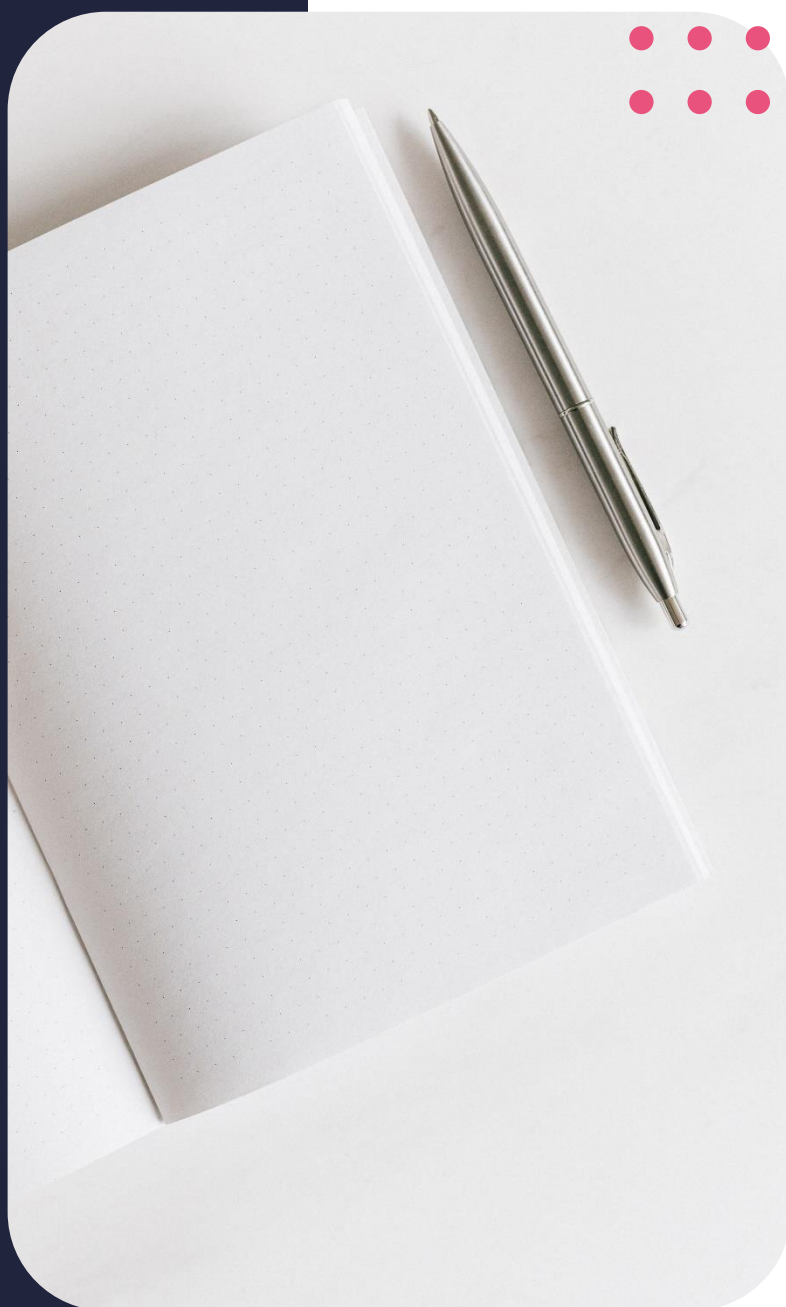
Diploma in Leadership & Management

Why Leaders and Managers need to master the skill of Conflict Management



Contents

- 3 Lesson 4 Objectives
 - Lesson Introduction
 - Key reading materials
- 4 Communication approaches to take in time of conflict
- 5 The cost of conflict
- 6 Here is an example of a conflict management exercise
- 11 Assertiveness exercises
- 12 Bibliography



Lesson 4 Objectives

- The importance of conflict management
- Negotiation
- Being assertive in times of conflict

Lesson Introduction

According to (Lenski, n.d.) “Conflict: A state of disharmony, perhaps long-term. Negotiation: Discussion aimed at finding common ground or mutual agreement. Mediation: A process for resolving disputes and conflict in which another person, substantively impartial, helps the parties negotiate a solution.”

Key reading materials

- <https://lattice.com/library/conflict-management-skills-for-every-manager>
- <https://www.theglobeandmail.com/report-on-business/careers/leadership-lab/the-long-term-costs-of-not-resolving-workplace-conflicts/article25527147/>
- <https://the-conflictexpert.com/2019/05/16/how-unresolved-conflict-impacts-your-mental-health/#:~:text=How%20Conflict%20Affects%20Mental%20Health,are%20already%20in%20financial%20difficulties.>

Communication approaches to take in time of conflict



Here are some ways you can communicate more effectively in order to overcome some of the conflict situations that you're currently facing.

Address the issue directly and immediately:

When you see conflict in your team or between individuals, it's time to step in. Managers and leaders need to address conflict situations within a timely matter. The more you wait, the bigger the issue becomes. "Not addressing the conflict until a later time allows resentments to simmer," said Nick Kamboj, CEO of Aston & James LLC. It's important to address the issue immediately and transparently.

Set clear expectations

According to (Kuligowski, 2016) "If people don't understand what the organization, their manager, or their teammates expect, confusion and conflict can result," Mitchell added. "Set expectations early, beginning with the job interview and again during the first days of employment." When you set expectations everyone has a clear understanding of what is expected, by whom, and by when. It helps when everyone has the same understanding of the task and what the team is doing.

Be fair

3 Give all parties a chance to speak and explain what is happening. Then you are able to guide the communication and be fair with the solution. There is nothing worse than an employee who does not feel heard or does not feel understood. Make sure that you're taking the time to investigate, get honest feedback in invest your time to ensure the conflict gets solved for the long-term.

The cost of conflict



According to (Scannell): "because conflict is a subject where there is a tendency to feel great discomfort, many may choose to simply ignore conflict. The danger in this approach is that the conflict festers under the surface and then bubbles up in subtle ways. Perhaps a team member is unresponsive to an e-mail request, or someone refuses to ask for help and consequently takes far longer than necessary on a task, or people simply avoid each other.

Conflict under the surface is very disruptive. It fractures a team as people choose sides and try to build up their forces. It fosters competition, distrust, poor communication, and low productivity.”

Conflict is easy to ignore or avoid at the moment, but in the long-term, the cost of the conflict will increase. Employees will start to avoid work, get sick, mental health will go down, communication will decrease and different parts of the company will be impacted. The company as a whole will suffer the longer conflict is left without management and without addressing the issues

Here is an example of a conflict management exercise



According to (Scannell)

OBJECTIVES

- To understand our perception of conflict
- To consider a different perspective on the conflict
- To learn techniques to better handle conflict
- To build trust

Group Size

Any

Materials

One copy of the Conflict—How Do You See It? handout (provided) for each participant, pens

Time

30 to 40 minutes

Procedure

Conflict can provide the spark that often leads to better solutions, creativity, and collaboration. This activity helps team members to: (1) become more comfortable with conflict, (2) consider the positive aspects of conflict, and (3) understand the possible benefits to themselves and the team. Have participants pair up. Provide each person with a copy of the handout. Allow 10 to 15 minutes for partners to interview each other. Follow with a group discussion of the interviews and then go over the discussion questions.

Tips

Follow this activity with the game Positive Spin.

Variations

Have team members switch partners every three questions to increase the level of trust within the team.

Discussion Questions

1. Were your partner's perspectives different from your perspective?
 2. What were some things you learned by considering another's perspective?
 3. Does discussing conflict like this makes it "less scary"? In what ways?
 4. Is conflict good or bad?
 5. What are some ways in which conflict is detrimental to the team?
 6. What are some ways in which conflict enriches the team?
-

Conflict—How Do You See It?

- 1.** How do you define conflict?

- 2.** What is your typical response to conflict?

- 3.** What is your greatest strength when dealing with conflict?

- 4.** If you could change one thing about the way you handle conflict, what would it be? Why?

- 5.** What is the most important outcome of conflict?

HANDOUT

6. In what ways have you seen your team benefit from conflict?

7. How can conflict be detrimental to a team?

8. What do you do when someone avoids conflict with you?

9. What are some reasons you choose to avoid conflict?

10. What can you do to promote a healthy attitude toward conflict within your team?

Here we have another example of an easy conflict management exercise that you can make use of.

It's called 'The Two Dollar Game'.

The Two Dollar Game:

According to (Tankersley, n.d.) can only be played once with any group of people because it has secret elements that are revealed in the end.

The game appears utterly simple at first: the group is divided into pairs, and each pair is given two dollars. The pair is instructed to divide the two dollars between the two people, in any way they both agree on. Unknown to each player, all players have received some type of secret instruction.

These instructions may require players to be competitive, generous, or compromising. Secret instructions may also include maintaining a certain demeanour. Further play details include two more surprise rounds as partners are changed and re-joined. Each round is debriefed afterward, and players discover the impact of tangible and intangible factors in negotiations. The surprise element of re-joining previous partners reveals the power of previous interactions in governing behaviour towards each other.

Negotiation exercises



According to (Karras, 2019)

“Role playing exercises: There is nothing better for honing your Effective Negotiating skills than role-playing with a friend or associate. We hear from our seminar participants that the case studies are especially effective because there’s nothing like adding some pressure to help us see where we make mistakes. Role-playing also helps point out how effective certain tactics can be in a pressured situation.”

“Find a friend or associate to practice with to help you focus on where your strengths and weaknesses are, and be sure to incorporate some of the elements that make a real negotiation complicated and unpredictable to get the most out of it.” (Karras, 2019)

Assertiveness exercises

According to (socialwork)

“An assertive person is one who acts in his/her own best interests, stands up for self, expresses feelings honestly, is in charge of self in interpersonal relations, and chooses for self. The basic message sent from an assertive person is “I’m OK and you’re OK.”

An assertive person is emotionally honest, direct, self-enhancing, and expressive. He/she feels confident, self-respecting at the time of his/her actions as well as later.

Assertive Body Language:

- Stand straight, steady, and directly face the people to whom you are speaking while maintaining eye contact.
- Speak in a clear, steady voice – loud enough for the people to whom you are speaking to hear you.
- Speak fluently, without hesitation, and with assurance and confidence.

Assertive worksheet:

Making Assertive Statements

Since assertiveness doesn't come naturally to most of us, let's practice a bit to perfect your technique. Take a look at the sample sentence structures below.

Use this template to communicate more assertively:

When you _____, I feel _____."

For example:

"When you raise your voice, I feel threatened."

Sometimes you need to tell a person how their behavior affected you:

"When you _____, then I _____, and I feel _____."

For example:

"When you arrive late, I have to wait, and I feel frustrated."

Bibliography

Lenski, T. (n.d.). Conflict Resolution Terms Defined. Retrieved from Mediate : <https://www.mediate.com/articles/LenskiTb120160606.cfm>

Kuligowski, K. (2016, March 9). Workplace Conflicts? Tips to Improve Communication. Retrieved from Business news daily: <https://www.businessnewsdaily.com/8766-resolving-workplace-conflicts.html>

Scannell, M. (n.d.). The big book of conflict resolution games . Toronto : McGraw Hills . 11

Tankersley, J. (n.d.). Conflict Resolution Games: 6 Ways to End Conflict in Your Office. Retrieved from Vital-learning : <https://www.vital-learning.com/blog/office-conflict-resolution-games>

Karras. (2019). EGOTIATING EXERCISES TO IMPROVE YOUR SKILLSET. Retrieved from Karrass: <https://www.karrass.com/en/blog/negotiation-exercises>
